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FINANCE MINISTER PRANAB MUKHERJEE WITH AFGHAN PRESIDENT HAMID KARZAI AT THE INAUGURATION OF THE DELARAM-ZARANJ HIGHWAY IN AFGHANISTAN IN JANUARY 2009

working for a foreign aid agency in Kabul for the past two years, has by now mastered the art of looking over his shoulder. Ever since the spate of attacks targeting Indians in Afghanistan since 2008, he keeps a very low profile. His survival mantra is simple. "Don't visit places frequented by Indians, keep changing guesthouses, don't follow any predictable pattern to work and maintain good relations with the local community who will warn you of any attack."

In fact, one of India's big ticket projects—the construction of the Afghan Parliament—was delayed by two years because of security fears as no contractors could be finalised. Now the worry is that other projects like the Salma Dam project in the Herat province may also get affected if the security situation worsens. "We have beefed up security considerably, and an elaborate plan is being implemented but our doctors and engineers working on our different projects around Afghanistan are the ones who are most vulnerable," a senior official told INDIA TODAY.

Under the new security procedures, Indians have been advised to

PAK GAMEPLAN

- **Provide sanctuary to Taliban in Federally Administered Tribal Areas/ North-Western Frontier Province and Balochistan. Ensure its survival.**
- **Lobby with Americans to keep the size of the Afghan National Army small and sub-optimal.**
- **Prevent natural economic linkages between Afghanistan and India—the most viable market for high value Afghan agricultural exports.**

move in groups, alter their timings and take different routes to work, but the big worry is that the morale of the staffers is low following the spate of attacks. Another serious worry is that India may be losing strategic ground in Afghanistan. Last year the top US commander in Afghanistan, General Stanley McChrystal, said in a report that India's growing influence in

Afghanistan could "exacerbate" regional tensions and encourage Pakistani "countermeasures" in Afghanistan or India. "While Indian activities largely benefit Afghan people, increasing Indian influence in Afghanistan is likely to exacerbate regional tensions and encourage Pakistani countermeasures in Afghanistan or India," added McChrystal.

Besides there is another added dimension. Analysts believe that with India beginning a dialogue with Pakistan without any tangible returns, the terrorists are getting emboldened. "Having refused to use economic and diplomatic levers, India is already undermining its position by talking to Pakistan. There is a connection what these attacks in Kabul and Pune demonstrate that far from autonomous, the military establishment in Pakistan is able to use terror groups at will against India," feels strategic analyst Brahma Chellaney.

Besides South Block's own assessment is that US policy of engaging Taliban may lead to an increase in terror emanating from Afghanistan and